

22-year-old has a shot at establishing himself as a mainstay in the batting order.

Apart from his addition, South Africa will hope consistent selections reap rewards. Aiden Markram, Tristan Stubbs and David Miller are still around from the last edition and can deliver better yields than they have managed of late. None of the three has a strike rate of more than 140 or an average of more than 30.

The Proteas' bowling line-up also wears a familiar look, with Kagiso Rabada and Anrich Nortje still in the ranks. However, their injury-prone nature has meant that Corbin Bosch leads South Africa's wicket-taking charts with 20 wickets from 13 matches, with Lungi Ngidi and Kwenza Maphaka next on the list.

Tabraiz Shamsi opting out of South Africa's central contracts since the last World Cup cost him a place in the squad, leaving George Linde to deputise for Keshav Maharaj in the spin department.

Spin-rich, batting-light

Afghanistan blazed a trail to the semifinals last time, but it would need more from its batters to emulate that success in the subcontinent. On sluggish wickets in the Caribbean, its spinners almost single-handedly tilted games in Afghanistan's favour.

While it sticks to the three-pronged attack of Rashid Khan (**pic, right**), Mujeeb Ur Rahman and Noor Ahmad, Afghanistan's underlying

batting numbers paint a worrying picture.

In this World Cup cycle, the side has scored at just 6.74 in the PowerPlay, the lowest among the 12 Full-Member nations.

Further, it remains a top-heavy team, leaning on Rahmanullah Gurbaz and Ibrahim Zadran.

Of the seven batters who have played at least 10 innings since July 2024, none strikes at more than 150, including Gurbaz and Zadran.

In conditions where dew will be an added hurdle for spinners, Afghanistan needs a contingency unit to step up.

The chasing pack

It will be all the more wary of the other two teams snapping at its heels. In the Asia Cup last year, UAE nearly chased down 170 against Afghanistan.

UAE's time in the Asia Cup, where it fell just four short of a chase of 170 against Afghanistan, and its 2-1 series win over Bangladesh in 2025 will remind teams that it is no pushover.

Canada qualified for the competition after winning the Americas Regional Final on home soil, where it overcame the Bahamas, the Cayman Islands and Bermuda. But a lack of experience against Full-Member nations might leave the North Americans in the lurch.

(Stats as of January 22)

Group D – T20 World Cup record

Team	Matches Played	Won	Lost	Tie	No Result	Titles won
South Africa	49	32	16	—	1	—
New Zealand	46	25	19	2	—	—
Afghanistan	30	12	18	—	—	—
UAE	6	1	5	—	—	—
Canada	4	1	2	—	1	—